ROAD DUST AND CONSTRUCTION ACTIVITIES MAKE UP 25% OF PM10 AND 17% OF PM2.5 IN DELHI'S AIR

In its revised criteria for ranking cities, it has doubled the points a city can earn with effective management of construction and demolition waste.

As expected, those at the receiving end of these rules—the real estate developers—bemoan how all construction work is stopped every time AQI reaches dangerous levels. "Even a few days of stoppage of work at sites delays projects by a couple of months," says Praveen Jain, vice-chairman, National Real Estate Development Council (NAREDCO), and promoter of real estate major, the Tulip Group. "Mobilisation of labour all over again and regaining the momentum at sites becomes a challenge. It is not fair to issue a blanket ban for the entire sector."

What most cities need is an authority akin to the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) in NCR and Adjoining Areas. It lays down a Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), which empowers it to take action based on AQI levels. Such action includes banning of construction activity and even closure of schools, if need be.

Amar Sarin, MD & CEO of the luxury homemaker TARC Group, offers another solution. "A synergy of advanced technologies and environmental awareness is essential to combat air pollution due to construction," he says. Measures like installing artificial rain-watering systems to control dust and integrating green spaces for natural filtration are some of the measures he recommends. There is also "prefab" technology, wherein concrete blocks are prefabricated in factories and transported to the site. ■



AGRICULTURE

Unhappy Seeders

The government's schemes are not incentive enough for farmers to shift from stubble burning or paddy cultivation

The problems are fairly well known and repeated often enough. The burning of paddy stubble by the farmers of Punjab to prepare the land for the sowing of the wheat crop for the rabi season has long contributed to haze hood, as it is known, over Delhi and its environs. It has its provenance in the directive, circa 2010, that Haryana and Punjab farmers delay the paddy sowing season by a month due to severe drinking water shortages during summer. The delayed sowing meant the kharif crop was harvested in November instead of late September-early October. By this time, the winds in the Indo-Gangetic plains begin to ease. What compounds matters is the bowl-shaped topography of the NCR and the low-lying Gangetic plains, which act as a sink for the smog to settle in for days on end until strong winds or rains relieve Delhi's air of its particulate matter miseries.

The problem got worse this year. Heavy and continuous rains in north India delayed the harvest and the crop's arrival in the market. Punjab and Haryana farmers were advised to sow the rabi wheat crop from the first fortnight of November as delayed sowing could result in a drop in crop yield. The staggered harvest left a very small window to